

18 > Settings that matter

in a meeting. Set vibration intensity so you can feel alerts without the phone rattling like a toolbox.

Search for Do Not Disturb. Configure exceptions for starred contacts, family members, repeated callers, alarms and calendar events. This is essential if you want the phone quiet at night but still reachable during emergencies.

Also check Live Caption if your phone supports it. It can caption speech from supported media on the device, which is useful when watching a video without headphones, understanding accents, or helping someone with hearing difficulty. Accessibility settings often hide some of Android's most practical tools.

Network settings: your phone is only as smart as its connection

Android network settings are especially important in India because users often juggle dual SIMs, weak indoor coverage, prepaid plans, public Wi-Fi, roaming, hotspot sharing and UPI verification.

Open Network & internet or Connections. Check your SIM names, default mobile data SIM, default calling SIM and default SMS SIM. If your UPI-linked number is on SIM 2, make sure SMS behaviour is correct. If your office number is separate, avoid accidentally calling clients from your personal number.

Turn on Wi-Fi calling if your operator and phone support it. This can improve call reliability indoors. Also check Data Saver. It restricts background data for many apps, which can help on limited data packs, but may delay sync, uploads or notifications. Use it when travelling, roaming or near the end of a prepaid cycle.

Check hotspot settings too. Change the hotspot password from the default if needed. Use WPA2 or WPA3 security where available. Do not leave hotspot on after sharing data with a laptop or friend. It drains battery and can leak data allowance.

Private DNS: small switch, useful protection

Private DNS is one of those settings that sounds more technical than it is. DNS is the system that helps translate website names into internet addresses. Private DNS can encrypt DNS queries using supported providers, improving privacy and sometimes helping block known malicious domains depending on the service you choose.

Android supports a Private DNS setting where users can select automatic mode or specify a provider hostname. You will usually find it by searching Private DNS in Settings.

For general users, Automatic is safe. Advanced users may use a trusted DNS provider that supports DNS-over-TLS. Do not randomly copy a hostname from a forum. DNS providers can affect browsing reliability and privacy, so choose carefully.

Step-by-step: check Private DNS

- Open Settings.
- Search Private DNS.

- Tap the result.
 - Choose Automatic if you are unsure.
 - Choose Private DNS provider hostname only if you trust the provider.
 - Save and test normal browsing, UPI apps, banking apps and streaming apps.
- If important apps stop working, revert to Automatic.

Permissions: the app does not need everything

Permissions decide what apps can access: camera, microphone, location, contacts, SMS, call logs, files, nearby devices, notifications and more. This is one of the most important Settings sections on Android. Google's Android help explains that users can manage permissions through Security & Privacy > Privacy > Permission manager, then select a permission type and change app access.

The Permission Manager is where you catch nonsense. A camera app needs the camera. A maps app needs location. A wallpaper app does not need your SMS. A calculator does not need your contacts. A casual game does not need microphone access.

Search Permission manager. Start with location, camera, microphone, contacts, SMS and files. Revoke anything suspicious. For location, prefer Allow only while using the app unless background location is genuinely needed. For many apps, approximate location is enough.

Android also offers a Privacy Dashboard on supported versions. Google's help says it lets users see which apps accessed permissions and then update access if needed. Android's privacy page also highlights Privacy Dashboard, permission controls, camera and microphone controls, and data safety information as user-facing privacy tools.

Step-by-step: run a 15-minute permission audit

- Open Settings.
- Search Privacy Dashboard.
- Check recent camera, microphone and location access.
- Tap any app you do not recognise or do not trust.
- Change the permission to Don't allow or Ask every time, if available.
- Now search Permission manager.
- Open Location and remove background access from apps that do not need it.
- Open SMS and Phone permissions. Be strict.
- Open Files and media or Photos and videos. Limit access where possible.
- Repeat this once every month.

This is the Android equivalent of checking who has keys to your house.